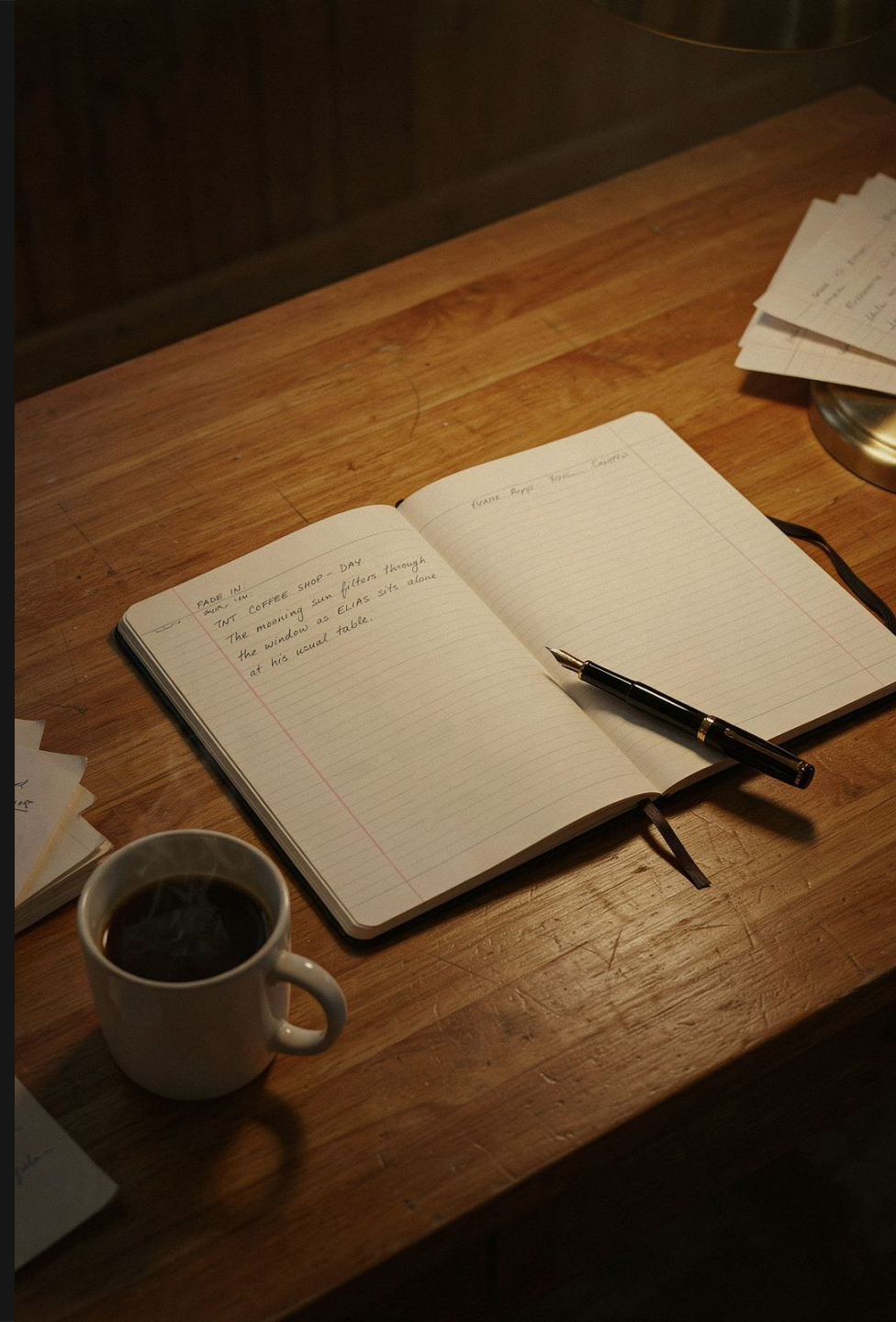


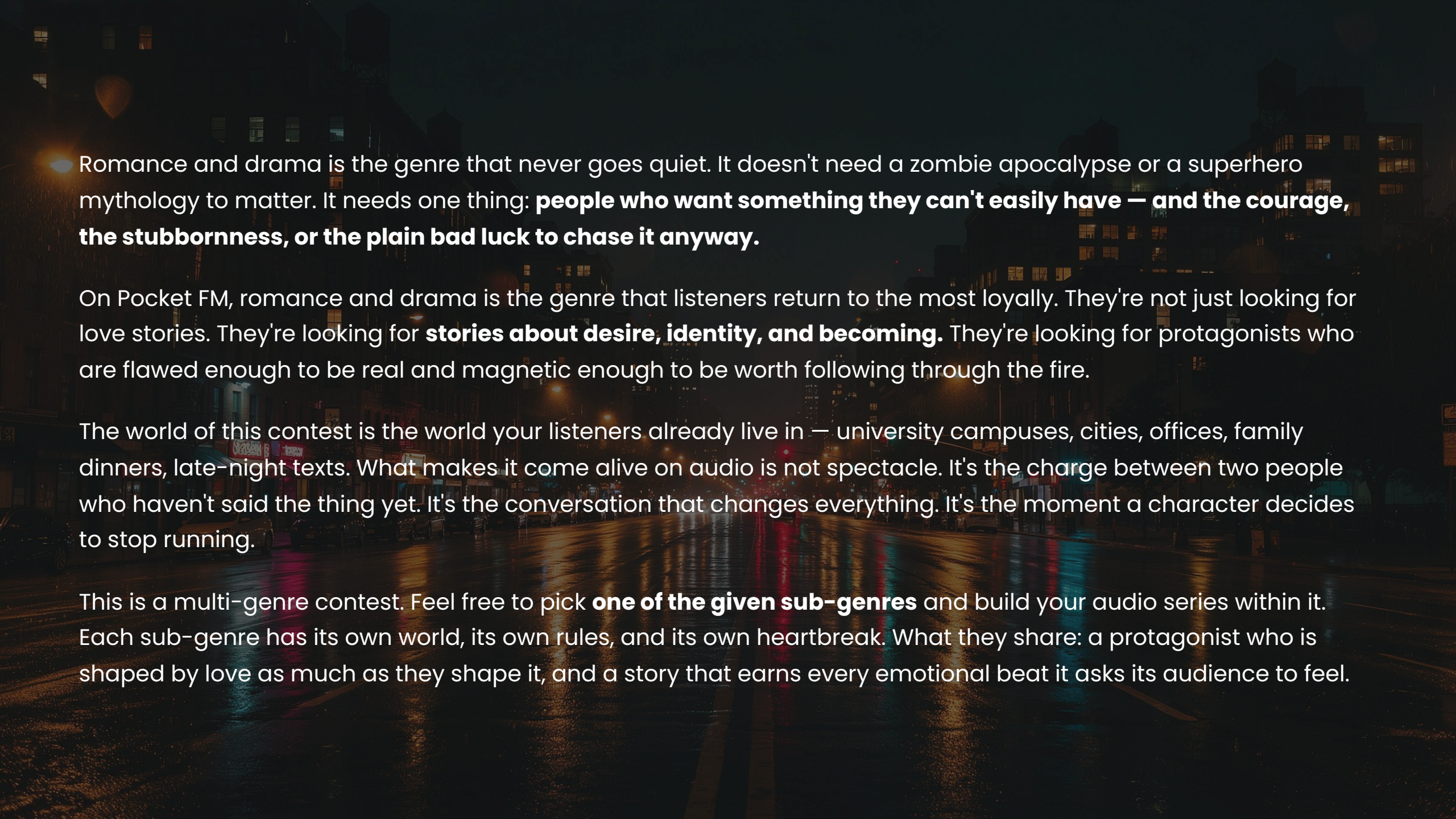


Where the Heart Leads

Genre: Romance & Drama

Part 1 – Creative Bible





Romance and drama is the genre that never goes quiet. It doesn't need a zombie apocalypse or a superhero mythology to matter. It needs one thing: **people who want something they can't easily have — and the courage, the stubbornness, or the plain bad luck to chase it anyway.**

On Pocket FM, romance and drama is the genre that listeners return to the most loyally. They're not just looking for love stories. They're looking for **stories about desire, identity, and becoming.** They're looking for protagonists who are flawed enough to be real and magnetic enough to be worth following through the fire.

The world of this contest is the world your listeners already live in — university campuses, cities, offices, family dinners, late-night texts. What makes it come alive on audio is not spectacle. It's the charge between two people who haven't said the thing yet. It's the conversation that changes everything. It's the moment a character decides to stop running.

This is a multi-genre contest. Feel free to pick **one of the given sub-genres** and build your audio series within it. Each sub-genre has its own world, its own rules, and its own heartbreak. What they share: a protagonist who is shaped by love as much as they shape it, and a story that earns every emotional beat it asks its audience to feel.

A romantic couple is shown in silhouette, embracing on a wet city street at night. The street is wet and reflects the warm, yellowish light from the buildings and street lamps. The couple is standing in the middle of the street, facing each other. The background shows a row of multi-story buildings with lit windows, creating a bokeh effect. The overall mood is intimate and romantic.

Top 6 Tropes for Romance Drama On Pocket FM

Pick the one of your choice and write the best version of it you can, keeping in mind the 100-hour engine:

Contemporary Romance

Two people. Real life. Every reason not to fall. Contemporary romance is the purest expression of the genre because nothing stands between the characters except themselves. No magic systems. No supernatural destinies. No billionaires or fairy tales. Just two fully realized people navigating timing, emotional baggage, family expectations, careers, distance, miscommunication, and the terrifying vulnerability of choosing someone who can hurt them. The world is familiar, but the emotions are anything but ordinary.

The best contemporary romances don't ask, *Will they save the world?* They ask, *Can they build a life together despite everything life keeps throwing at them?* Every obstacle is deeply human, making every breakthrough feel deeply earned. Think *When Harry Met Sally* stretched into a 100-hour slow burn, the aching, years-spanning yearning of *One Day*, or the messy, irresistible chemistry of *Anyone But You*.

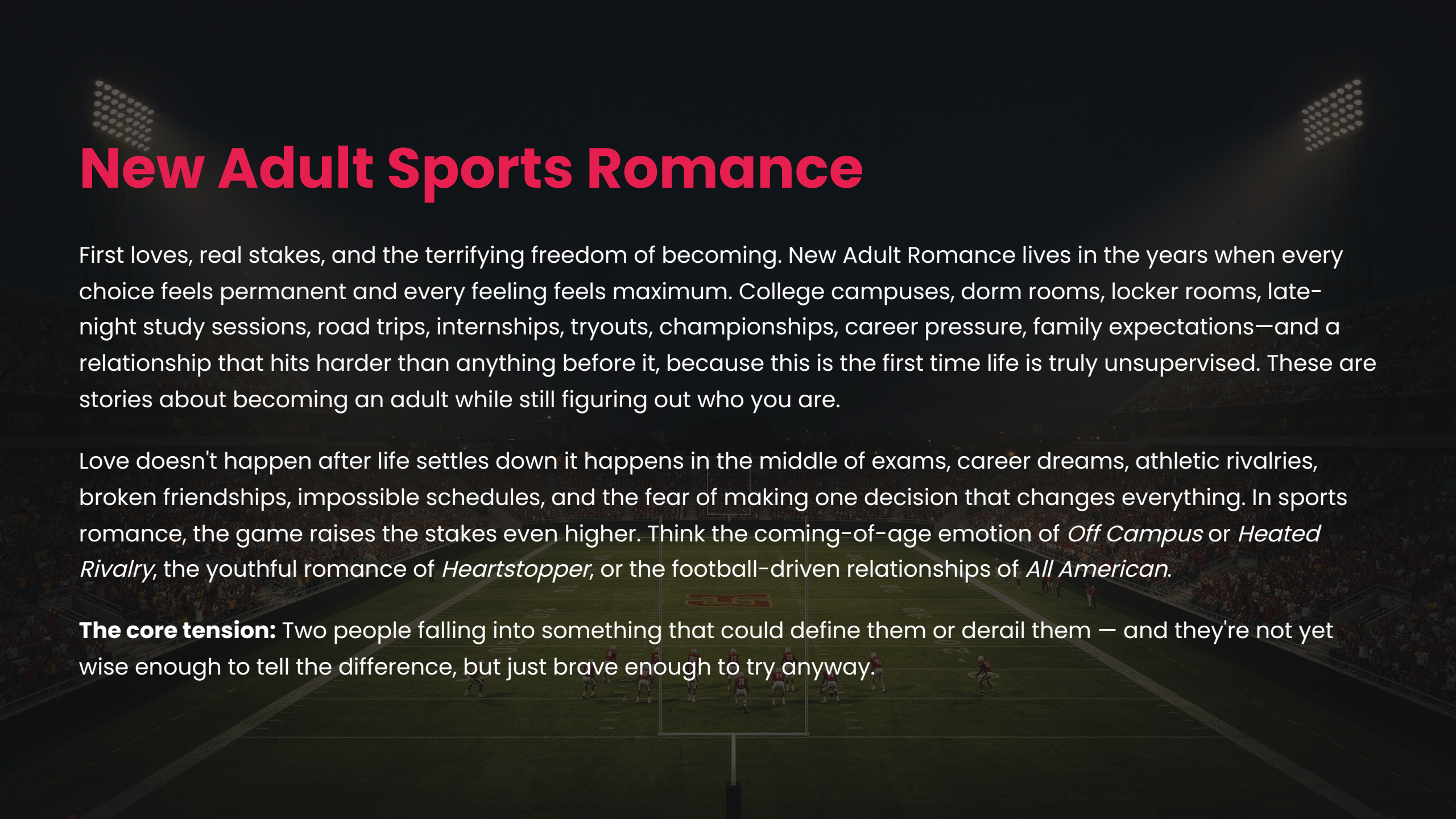
The core tension: Two people who want each other, separated by exactly one thing they'll have to dismantle or sacrifice. The longer they orbit, the higher the cost — and the more the listener needs them to.

Female Drama

One woman. Everything she built and everything that's threatening to take it apart. Female drama isn't primarily about romance. It's about a woman's fight to become herself in a world that constantly asks her to be someone else. These stories explore hardship, sacrifice, ambition, family expectations, friendship, motherhood, loss, self-worth, and the quiet compromises that shape a life. They ask what a woman is willing to endure, what she's willing to give up, and, ultimately, what she's no longer willing to sacrifice.

Every victory is emotional before it's external. Every setback forces her to question not just what she wants, but who she wants to become. The story orbits her choices, with every relationship, pushing her toward the woman she's meant to be. Think the career-versus-self conflicts of *The Devil Wears Prada*, the reinvention and unexpected friendship of *The Intern*, or the emotional complexity of *Little Women*.

The core tension: She knows what she wants. Getting it will cost something she didn't plan to pay. The story is about whether she can live with the cost and who she becomes in the deciding.



New Adult Sports Romance

First loves, real stakes, and the terrifying freedom of becoming. New Adult Romance lives in the years when every choice feels permanent and every feeling feels maximum. College campuses, dorm rooms, locker rooms, late-night study sessions, road trips, internships, tryouts, championships, career pressure, family expectations—and a relationship that hits harder than anything before it, because this is the first time life is truly unsupervised. These are stories about becoming an adult while still figuring out who you are.

Love doesn't happen after life settles down it happens in the middle of exams, career dreams, athletic rivalries, broken friendships, impossible schedules, and the fear of making one decision that changes everything. In sports romance, the game raises the stakes even higher. Think the coming-of-age emotion of *Off Campus* or *Heated Rivalry*, the youthful romance of *Heartstopper*, or the football-driven relationships of *All American*.

The core tension: Two people falling into something that could define them or derail them — and they're not yet wise enough to tell the difference, but just brave enough to try anyway.

Workplace Drama

Deadlines. Ambition. Proximity. Every reason to stay professional—and every reason they can't. Workplace romance drama thrives on two people who are forced into each other's orbit long before they're ready to admit what they're feeling. Whether they're rivals competing for the same promotion, partners chasing an impossible deadline, a boss and an employee navigating blurred boundaries, or colleagues building something together, the office becomes the pressure cooker where attraction and ambition collide.

These stories aren't just about falling in love they're about balancing love against identity, reputation, and career. Think the witty office banter of *The Office*, the irresistible chemistry of *The Hating Game*, the ambition-versus-love conflicts of *The Proposal*, or the corporate tension of *Suits*.

The core tension: Two people whose professional lives demand distance while their personal lives demand the opposite. Every step toward each other risks their reputation, their careers, or the goals they've spent years chasing. They can't simply walk away from each other and that's exactly what makes every glance, every victory, every betrayal, and every confession impossible to ignore.

Revenge Drama

They lost everything. Now the world that broke them is about to learn what it created. Contemporary revenge drama is about a person reclaiming power after betrayal, humiliation, injustice, or devastating loss. Revenge is never just about settling a score; it's about reclaiming the life, identity, dignity, or future that someone tried to steal. These stories are fueled as much by resilience as by rage, following protagonists who refuse to remain victims even when fighting back demands everything they have. The emotional hook is transformation. They begin betrayed, underestimated, discarded, or broken.

Piece by piece, they rebuild themselves—earning influence, exposing secrets, outsmarting enemies, and forcing those who wronged them to face the consequences of their actions. Think the emotional resilience of *Maid*, the public reckoning of *Big Little Lies*, the long-game satisfaction of *Insta Millionaire*, or the calculated rise and revenge of *The Glory*.

The core tension: They can finally destroy the people who ruined their lives but revenge demands sacrifices that threaten to change them forever. The closer they get to justice, the more they risk losing the very humanity they set out to reclaim.

Mafia Romance

Power. Loyalty. Violence. Desire. Mafia romance begins where love becomes dangerous. One or both lovers belong to a world built on crime, loyalty, family, and blood debts, where every decision has consequences far beyond the relationship. Love isn't an escape from this world, but it pulls them deeper into it. The appeal lies in the collision between ruthless power and unexpected vulnerability. Beneath the wealth, influence, and violence are deeply possessive characters forced to choose between love and legacy, desire and duty, family and freedom.

Whether it's an arranged marriage, enemies forced into an alliance, rival crime families, bodyguard protection, or a reluctant queen rising beside a king, the romance unfolds under relentless pressure because failure isn't heartbreak, it's death. Think the family loyalty of *The Godfather*, the crime-world politics of *Peaky Blinders*, or the dangerous chemistry of *365 Days*.

The core tension: They are falling in love inside a world where trust is a luxury and weakness is fatal. To choose each other means risking family, power, and survival and the people who want them apart will never stop coming.

And Your Protagonist?

Across every romance and drama sub-genre, your lead carries the same responsibility: they have to be worth following. They always want something desperately, they're emotionally unequipped to get it, and every attempt to reach it reveals who they truly are. Whether they're chasing love, revenge, success, freedom, or redemption, the audience should feel that this goal matters because it matters to *them*.

The strongest protagonists are driven by an emotional wound that shapes every choice they make. Their greatest strength is often the armor they built to survive, and that same armor becomes the obstacle keeping them from the life they truly want.



Romance and drama protagonists often begin as one of these emotional archetypes:

- **The Controlled One**

Betrayal taught them that vulnerability is dangerous. They've mistaken emotional distance for peace.

- **The Overcorrector**

They love too deeply and sacrifice too much, believing they must earn the affection they crave.

- **The Achiever**

Success became their identity. They've built a life worth admiring but not one worth living.

- **The One Who Stayed**

They accepted the life they were handed until one opportunity—or one person—made them want more.

- **The Returner**

They've come back to a place, person, or past they thought they'd escaped, only to discover old wounds still waiting.

- **The Survivor**

Betrayed or underestimated, they've rebuilt themselves around anger, control, or revenge.

- **The Protector**

They carry everyone else's burdens, convinced that putting themselves first would make everything fall apart.

One principle ties them all together: **The flaw is how the wound survives.**

Like a workaholic mistakes ambition for fulfillment. A mafia heir mistakes possession for love. A revenge seeker mistakes justice for healing. A college athlete mistakes intensity for forever.

The arc is watching that survival strategy meet the one thing it can't overcome. By the end, your protagonist shouldn't just get what they wanted—they should become someone who could never have achieved it in Chapter One.

Your Mission

Choose one of the many sub-genres mentioned. Then write a story that earns its feelings. Every episode should do two things: move the plot, and deepen the emotional truth. **The plot is the excuse. The feelings are the point.** If your listener finishes an episode and doesn't feel something they need to resolve, you haven't made them need the next one.

Let the central relationship be the mirror your protagonist can't look away from. The other person doesn't just attract them. They **challenge** them, revealing something about the protagonist they weren't ready to see. And when you build to your climax, make sure it lands on something true. **The question your story has to answer: Can someone who's been protecting themselves from love finally decide the risk is worth it? And what do they have to give up to get there?**

Remember three things:

Love is not the reward at the end; it is the pressure that builds throughout.

Let every scene be shaped by what the characters can't yet say to each other.

Drama lives in the gap between what a character wants and what they're willing to admit they want.

Close that gap slowly.

The best romance and drama stories are honest about the cost of connection.

What does being loved require of your protagonist?



Example Ideas

The examples below are here to point your story in a direction. Use them as a launchpad for your own imagination, don't just copy them.

Each sub-genre gets two examples to show the range of what's possible within it.



CONTEMPORARY ROMANCE

Example 1

She built a successful career as a Chicago-based architect, believing that being indispensable was the only way to stay safe after losing everything when her father's business collapsed. Then the developer who buys her firm turns out to be the man she shared one unforgettable night with years ago. What she doesn't know is that he was connected to the investment firm responsible for her family's downfall.

As high-stakes projects, corporate rivalries, family revelations, and impossible career choices force them together, buried truths threaten both their futures and the future of her company.

She must decide whether to keep holding on to the past or risk trusting the man she should hate most.

Example 2

He grew up in a family that treated love as a transaction. His parents stayed together because leaving cost too much, and he learned early that wanting too much from the people closest to you was how you ended up humiliated. So he became the person everyone could count on without ever asking for anything back. That's how he became her best friend.

For twelve years, he has been the safest relationship in both their lives because he made sure it never cost either of them anything real. Then she gets engaged to someone, and the engagement forces him to look directly at the thing he has spent four years carefully not looking at. Because he's afraid if she loves her back, he still won't be able to let himself have it.

As the wedding approaches, the question is: What do you do when the life you built to protect yourself from pain has quietly become the source of it?

FEMALE DRAMA

Example 1

She built a successful media company to prove that a woman never has to lose herself for love, the way her mother did. Now, at the biggest moment of her career, she's offered a life-changing acquisition—but only if she gives up the creative voice that made her company unique.

At the same time, her estranged co-founder and former best friend returns, forcing her to confront a betrayal neither of them has ever spoken about. As business and old emotions collide, she must decide whether she's protecting everything she's built or pushing away everyone who ever wanted to stay.

Every victory comes at a personal cost, asking one question: can she trust love without losing herself?



Example 2

She married a man right out of university because she believed love meant sacrifice. For ten years, she slowly disappeared inside a marriage that demanded she be accommodating, while her husband took a mistress – her ex-best friend – for himself. Now, at 38, she's back in the city she left for him, carrying a wound deeper than divorce: the belief that her own needs are selfish and that love always requires her to make herself smaller.

She starts a relationship with a man who is uncomplicated and kind in all the ways her marriage was not, but she keeps waiting for the catch because she no longer trusts happiness that doesn't have strings attached.

But when her ex-husband reappears, full of apologies and promises to become the man she always wanted, she's forced to confront the hardest question of all: Is she choosing between two men—or between the woman she used to be and the woman she's finally becoming?



NEW ADULT SPORTS ROMANCE

Example 1

She's the university's newest nepo student recruit in the cheerleading squad. He's the basketball team's captain, playing the final season that will decide his professional future. They clash over leadership, ambition, and what it takes to win. But when injuries, ruthless rivals, and championship pressure force them onto the same side, competition slowly turns into something far more dangerous.

Every new tournament, rival team, injury, transfer, and media attention shape their evolving friendship and push them closer to falling in love.

Can two people chasing the same dream fall in love without becoming obstacles to each other's future?

Example 2

He transferred to a new college in his second year, hoping to leave behind the one mistake that still haunts him. Determined never to be that person again, he becomes known for his honesty and integrity—until the past returns in the form of the very person he failed to protect.

Meanwhile, he grows close to a fearless, curious classmate, the school's face in the ice hockey championship – who sees the person he's trying to become, not the one he used to be. As a growing friendship, campus politics, and old secrets collide, he's forced to choose between protecting the life he's rebuilt or finally telling the truth that could destroy her budding career.

When his darkest secret comes to light, will love survive the truth, or is redemption something he has to earn alone?



WORKPLACE ROMANCE

Example 1

She built her career after growing up watching her mother sacrifice every dream for the family, and she's sworn she'll never need anyone to succeed. He's the company's celebrated turnaround specialist who learned long ago that getting close to people only makes losing them hurt more. When they're forced to co-lead a failing division, they're also competing for the same promotion.

Every success pulls them closer. Every office victory gives only one of them an advantage as they navigate product launches, office politics, shifting alliances, promotions, layoffs, mergers, client crises, workplace rivalries, and changing leadership that keep forcing them to choose between ambition and each other.

Can love survive when only one person can win?

Example 2

After her first startup failed publicly, she's terrified of trusting anyone with her dreams again. He's a brilliant but emotionally distant founder whose last business partner stole his company. Together they build a startup that suddenly becomes everyone's target.

As investors, competitors, ex-partners, and impossible deadlines close in, the company becomes inseparable from their relationship. But as they take on these challenges, more of them pour in, including funding rounds, scaling challenges, and media attention on family scandals, and old wounds start to open up.

What happens when the person you trust most also has the power to destroy everything you've built?



REVENGE DRAMA

Example 1

She spent fifteen years believing that being a good wife meant putting herself last. When her husband leaves her for someone younger and pushes her out of the business they built together, she realizes her greatest wound isn't betrayal; it's that she stopped believing she deserved more.

Instead of chasing him, she rebuilds herself until the life he discarded becomes the one everyone envies. Divorce battles, career reinvention, family conflicts, public reputation, legal disputes, new relationships, business success, and old enemies returning.

When the people who broke you want you back, is revenge choosing them or never needing them again?





Example 2

He exposed the financial fraud that was draining his family business and paid for it with everything. Framed by the people he trusted most, he lost his inheritance, his reputation, and the woman he loved. Forced to disappear, he spends years rebuilding his life overseas, transforming himself from a disgraced nobody into a billionaire entrepreneur whose name now opens every door that was once slammed in his face. When he returns, no one recognizes the man they destroyed.

But beneath the wealth, influence, and carefully crafted image is someone who still carries the wound of betrayal. One by one, he begins dismantling the empire his enemies stole, exposing secrets they've buried for years all while discovering that revenge is far easier than deciding who deserves his forgiveness.

When you finally have the power to destroy everyone who wronged you, will revenge heal the man they broke or complete his transformation into someone they created?



MAFIA ROMANCE

Example 1

She grew up believing every mafia family destroys everything it touches after her father was murdered in a gang war. He's the heir to the family she's been taught to hate. To prevent a bloody conflict, they're forced into an arranged marriage neither of them wants.

Every day together makes the enemy harder to hate, and the people around them become more determined to keep them apart. Mafia wars, shifting alliances, family politics, betrayals, succession battles, law enforcement pressure, rival syndicates, and the struggle to build an empire together completely try to hijack their budding romance.

Can they build a future together without betraying the families that made them who they are?



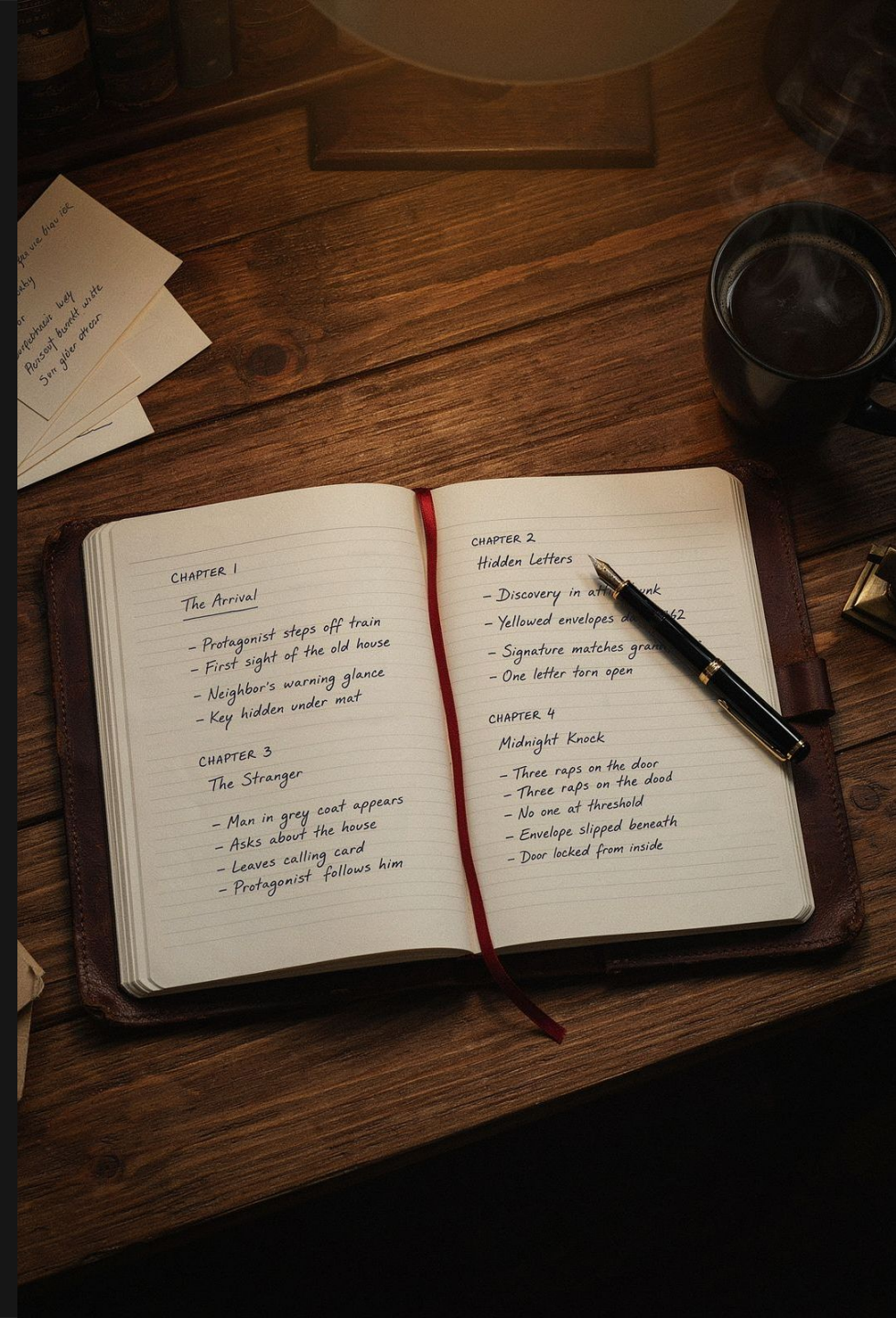
Example 2

She inherited a criminal empire she never wanted after losing her family overnight. He is her father's most righteous disciple, who blames himself for failing to protect the people who mattered most and refuses to fail again. Assigned as her bodyguard, he keeps his distance until every assassination attempt pushes them closer.

Love becomes the one weakness their enemies know how to exploit. But every power struggle, rival family, hidden betrayal, expanding criminal empire, dangerous alliance, and an ever-escalating war for control push them closer to each other, threatening their secrets to spill in front of the world.

Can they protect each other without becoming each other's greatest vulnerability?

Part 2 : Structural Framework



Chapter 1 Checklist

Your first chapter has to land these beats:

The Protagonist's Entry

Drop us into her or his world at a moment of pressure — show us what she's good at and what it costs her to be good at it.

The Wound She's Living Around

The old hurt, the thing she decided after the last time, visible in how she behaves.

The Life That Needs Disrupting

A relationship on autopilot, a routine that looks like contentment, a version of herself she's settled into.

The World She Moves Through

The specific texture of her daily life — the city, the campus, the locker room, the office.

The Inciting Person or Event

The arrival that puts the protagonist and the central conflict in the same room for the first time.

A Human Anchor

Someone who keeps her grounded — a friend, a sibling, a mentor — who will tell her hard truths.

The First Real Moment

One scene where something true passes between the protagonist and the person who will change her.

The Ground Shifts

End on a revelation, a choice she can't take back, or a realization she can't unfeel.

Chapter 1–5 Checklist

Across Chapters 1 through 5, make sure you hit:

The Gap Widens

The obstacle deepens and reveals its true nature.

A Moment of Real Closeness

A threshold crossed — a confession, a vulnerability, a moment neither of them expected.

The Interference

An external force — a past relationship resurfacing, a professional pressure, a secret — that threatens what's forming.

The Personal Life Bleeding In

The arc of the protagonist's inner life should visibly intersect with the central story.

A Misread or Miscommunication

Both parties read the same scene entirely differently — and the listener can see why both of them are wrong.

An Unexpected Ally or Mirror

Someone to fall back on, who makes her see something she'd been refusing to.

The Line She Crosses

She does something she said she wouldn't. It should feel inevitable.

The Point of No Return

By the end of Chapter 5, she can no longer pretend she doesn't want what she wants.

10 Questions to Guide You

These 10 questions will shape the foundation of your story. Every answer reveals something about your protagonist, the world they're moving through, and the choices they'll be forced to make.

Read the options, then pick the one that best fits your story — or create your own.



Questions 1 & 2

Who is your protagonist?

- The Guarded One: Built her entire personality around not needing people — and has just met the one person she can't make herself not need.
- The Overachiever: Sense of self bound up in performance — about to learn that being the best at something doesn't protect you from anything.
- The Caretaker: Spent so long looking after others that she has no idea what she actually wants for herself. The
- Rebuilder: In the aftermath of a loss — a relationship, a career, a version of herself — trying to figure out what comes next.

→ With these options in mind, write your answer!

What is her personal demon?

- The Fear of Repetition: Been here before, it ended badly, built a life around making sure it never happened again. The story is the happening-again.
- The Imposter Syndrome: Doesn't fully believe she deserves the things she's built. Every good thing feels provisional.
- The Loyalty Trap: Will stay in relationships long past the point they're healthy, because leaving feels like failure.
- The Emotional Lockdown: Knows how to present herself and be what people need. Has no idea what she actually feels.

→ With these options in mind, write your answer!

Questions 3 & 4

What pulls her into the central conflict?

- An Unavoidable Person: Someone re-enters or enters her life in a context she can't exit — a job, a class, a team, a shared space.
- A Forced Partnership: Circumstances require her to work with or rely on someone she would not have chosen.
- A Deadline or Threshold: A birthday, graduation, professional milestone — something with a clock that forces decisions she's been avoiding.
- A Truth She Can No Longer Ignore: Something she's been not-thinking about finally surfaces in a form she can't dismiss.

→ With these options in mind, write your answer!

Who is the person who changes everything?

- The One She Shouldn't Want: Wrong timing, wrong history — and somehow the only person in the room who sees her clearly.
- The One She Already Has: A relationship she thought was settled, more complicated than she allowed herself to know.
- The One She Underestimated: Someone she initially dismissed, whose real nature reveals itself in a way she wasn't prepared for.
- The One Who Leaves First: Someone who made her feel safe, then chose something else — and whose leaving forces her to understand what she wanted.

→ *With these options in mind, write your answer!*

Questions 5 & 6

What does the world or system pressure her with?

- Professional Stakes: A career move, a competition, a promotion — choosing between ambitions and heart.
- Family Expectation: A parent, a sibling, a tradition — something that makes her choices feel like a verdict on who she is.
- Social Pressure: A reputation or image she's constructed that makes the right personal choice feel like a public risk.
- Time: The simple, brutal pressure of a window closing — a season ending, a person leaving, an opportunity that won't come again.

→ With these options in mind, write your answer!

Which line does she cross?

- She Lets Someone In: She tells the truth — the real one, not the version she uses to keep people at arm's length.
- She Chooses Herself: She says no to what she's supposed to want and yes to what she actually wants.
- She Breaks the Rule She Made: The thing she said she'd never do again. She does it.
- She Walks Away: She leaves something she built carefully and no longer recognizes herself inside.

→ With these options in mind, write your answer!

Questions 7 & 8

Who is her unexpected ally?

- The Friend Who Tells the Truth: The one person who will say the thing everyone else is carefully not saying.
- The Rival Who Becomes Real: Someone she was supposed to compete with, who turns out to understand her position most clearly.
- The Outsider: Someone who knows nothing of her history and responds only to who she is right now.
- The Person She Wronged: Someone from her past who re-enters with enough generosity to give her what she needs to move forward.

→ With these options in mind, write your answer!

What is at stake personally?

- Her Sense of Herself: The story will require her to revise the story she's been telling about who she is.
- A Relationship That Pre-dates the Story: A friendship, a family bond — something she built before that will be tested.
- Her Future: A version of her life she's been moving toward that is no longer compatible with what she's becoming.
- Her Past: A guilt, a grief, an old choice — that has to be set down before she can move forward.

→ With these options in mind, write your answer!

Questions 9 & 10

What is the hardest test of her conscience?

- Stay or Go: Someone needs her to stay. Something needs her to leave. She cannot do both.
- Honest or Kind: The truth will hurt someone she loves. The lie protects them and hollows her out.
- Herself or Someone Else: Her growth requires something another person needs her not to do.
- Trust or Self-Protect: Someone is offering her something real. Every instinct she's built says not to take it.

→ With these options in mind, write your answer!

What does the ending feel like?

- Hard-Won: They found each other, or they found their true selves, and the listener earned every moment of it.
- Bittersweet: They got the most important thing they wanted, but not all the things. The gain is real, and so is the growth arc that the protagonist charts out for themselves, but it all comes at a cost.
- Open: They are at a threshold. The story ends on a choice they're finally ready to make. It is a vow they make not to repeat their old mistakes.
- Complete: They become who they needed to become. Whether or not the central relationship ends where we hoped, the protagonist must have learned and grown through the ups and downs in the story.

→ With these options in mind, write your answer!



Tips for Building a Character Your Listeners Can't Leave

Three quick tests for a lead people stay with, even when she's making the wrong choice:

Tip 1: Can we feel for her, even when we can see her mistake?

Your protagonist is going to do things that frustrate your listener. They're going to push away the person who's good for them. Give them a history that makes their mistakes make sense without making them acceptable:

- **The formative rejection:** Someone she trusted that taught her a lesson she's now over-applying.
- **The thing she never got to say:** A loss or ending that had no proper closure, leaving him with a habit of not finishing his emotional sentences.
- **The version of love they were shown:** The model they grew up with that became the default architecture.
- **The bargain they made:** What they gave up in exchange for something else and whether that trade ever actually paid off.

Key: Their wound should make her sympathetic, not passive. We want to root for them to overcome it, not excuse them for letting it win.

Tip 2: Does they have something worth fighting for in herself?

Even a complicated protagonist needs qualities that make them worth watching; not despite their flaws, but woven into them:

- **They are competent at something:** Let them be genuinely good at the thing that matters to her. Competence is magnetic on audio.
- **They have a code:** Even an inconsistent one. The story will test those principles.
- **They are capable of loyalty:** She shows up for the people she's decided to show up for.
- **They can change her mind:** She can hear something and let it land. The story just takes a while to find the crack.

Key: These are what make listeners want her to get what they're after and make their worst moments feel like detours, not destinations.

Tip 3: Is there electricity in the central relationship?

The relationship at the heart of your story needs to do more than be sweet. It needs to charge the scenes it's in:

- **They see each other:** The other person notices the thing about the protagonist she's been hiding — and names it.
- **There's a specific language between them:** An inside reference, a way they talk that doesn't exist anywhere else in either of their lives.
- **The banter lands because the stakes are real:** Wit and tension work together when both people actually have something to lose.
- **The restraint is visible:** The things they don't say. The moments they pull back. Those are often the most electric moments of all.

Key: Listeners should be conducting the entire relationship in their heads between episodes. They should know what the characters feel before the characters do.

Building a Gripping Climax (Cliffhangers)

Keep your audience hooked from one episode to the next:

Drop a Hidden Truth

End on something true about the protagonist, the relationship, or the situation and immediately make clear there's something deeper underneath they don't yet know.

Ask the Question They Can't Shake

End on an unanswered question about loyalty, guilt, or who's coming next, so listeners have to know what she does.

Plan to Breadcrumb

Don't reveal everything the central relationship is about in three episodes. Let every ending give the listener one more piece of a picture they can feel is bigger than what they're being shown.

Leave Them on the Edge

Cut right after a moment that will mean two completely different things to the two people in it. The listener can see both meanings.

Freeze the Confrontation

End the episode exactly when something is about to happen — a confession, a confrontation, a choice. Not so the listener is cheated, but so they spend the time until the next episode already living in the scene.

This is your chance to choose from a range of high potential romance drama tropes and build a story around one central promise: every episode must drive the story through the protagonist.

In this contest, we want stories that earn their feelings, build addictive emotional momentum, and leave the listener needing one more episode.

Happy Writing!

